

“FIRE”

TEXT: [Matthew 3:11](#) (NKJV)

“I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance, but He who is coming after me is mightier than I, whose sandals I am not worthy to carry. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire.” [Acts 2:1-4](#)

(NKJV) *“When the Day of Pentecost had fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.² And suddenly there came a sound from heaven, as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled the whole house where they were sitting.³ Then there appeared to them divided*

tongues, as of fire, and one sat upon each of them.⁴ And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.”

INRO: The word fire denotes something that is unstoppable, it means to lick up. **Fire can destroy or it can purify.**

Throughout the Word of God, from Genesis to Revelations, we are told that there will be a fire in all of us! **We are built for fire**, whether you are 17 or 70 you will be driven by fire! We are a fireplace. The fire I am speaking of today is our

passions. We will either be on fire for God or we will burn with a passion for the world!

Proverbs 6:27-28 (NKJV) “*Can a man take fire to his bosom, And his clothes not be burned? 28 Can one walk on hot coals, And his feet not be seared?*”

We have heard all of our lives about sins of omission and sins of commission, but in reality we are really speaking of an issue which has to do with fire.

Indians used to call alcohol “fire water” and I’m convinced they knew more than the brilliant minds of this modern time! On television

commercials all you need to do
is pop the top and a blizzard
comes in! In reality, when the
alcohol begins to flow it kindles
a fire. The addict calls it a rush.
(Story of drunk attempting to
push back a train) (Lovers
become fighters and fighters
become lovers)

For decades the church has sat
around holding hands waiting
on the fire to fall. We don't
need to wait on the fire to come
to us we must kindle the fire.

The world doesn't sit around
and wait on the fire to fall, they
build one. What other reasons

would there be for people to go out on Friday and Saturday nights and drink away their hard earned dollars? What, besides a passion to fulfill lust would cause a person to gamble away their life's savings? The coupe in divorce court says the fire has gone out of our relationship!

If we are going to talk about fire, I want us to talk to someone who knows something about the subject. [David Murphy, Senior Captain HPD.](#)

FIREMAN INTERVIEW

- What are the goals of the fire department?
- Approximately how many fires have you worked?
- How many kinds of fire are there?
- Tell me about the two kinds of fire of which you speak.
- Tell me about the various aspects of fire.
- Does a fire normally draw a crowd?
- Do some of the people who come to a fire retrieve possessions, and possibly rescue someone from the house-a-fire?
- Why would you say people will come to a fire?

- Who returns the next day, once the fire is out?
- What do they do?

(Thank the fireman for the information that he has provided.)

I. STRANGE FIRE – THE FIRE OF SIN!

The wrong kind of fire is destructive. If the wrong fire is present, it could bring the house down to ashes! The wrong fire manifests itself through the works of the flesh.

How could someone risk it all with a fling, or risk stoning in

the Old Testament? I'll tell you why, because there is a strange fire in the fireplace of the heart and it is just our human nature to gravitate to the fire!

In the Bible, those who flirted with strange fire were made aware of its devastating consequences:

- [Nadab and Ahibu](#) attempted to furnish their own fire in ministering to the Lord. Because they were using strange fire the fire of God came down and devoured them.
- [David and Bathsheba](#) – When David saw her, a fire

began to burn. That was the beginning of the end!

Fire does not extinguish itself as long as it has oxygen and fuel! If we continue to feed the fire of sin and give it opportunity in our life it will burn until we are destroyed.

Some who are in this room today have been standing too close to the enemies fire! We cannot flirt with the fire and hope not to get burned.

There are four things that are never satisfied, and one of them is fire! [Proverbs 30:15-16](#)
(CEV) *“Greed has twins, each*

named “Give me!” There are four things that are never satisfied: 16 The world of the dead and a childless wife, the thirsty earth and a flaming fire.”

The fire of the world can never get enough. When the thrill is over there is an immediate need for more stimulation and gratification. Sin will take us farther than we intended to go; keep us longer than we intended to stay; and make us pay far more than we intended to pay! (Samson) Mark 8:36-37 (NKJV) *“For what will it profit a man if he gains the whole world, and loses his own*

**soul?37 “Or what will a man
give in exchange for his soul?””**

Unless we stay on fire with
Holy Ghost enthusiasm we will
be on fire with the passions of
the world!

II. RELIGIOUS FIRE!

There are many senseless things
that are done in the name of
religion!

- Religion flew jetliners into
the world trade center, the
pentagon and into the
ground on 9/11/01!
- Religion causes men,
women and young people to
strap a bomb to their body
and detonate it at just the

right time to take as many
lives as possible.

- Religion caused hundreds to drink poison at the direction of Jim Jones in Jonestown!
- Dozens of people go to a fiery grave at the insistence of David Koresh in Waco, Texas.

What could these people have been thinking of? What were they looking for? They were searching for something to be passionate about! People are so desperate for a passionate cause they will follow an Osama Bin Laden, Saddam Hussein, Jim Jones, or David Koresh!

The world is looking for the fire of God to put into the fireplace of their heart! They may not even know what they are searching for but until they discover God's fire everything else will leave them feeling empty. Some of the most vicious people on the face of the earth are religious people! Be careful about turning your back on religious folks, they will rip you to ribbons! (Story of woman who said she could not lay her tongue on the altar)

When the world comes to
Christian Temple will they find

the fire of God or will they find religious fire? Religious fire is more dangerous than the fire of the word because religious fire causes the individual to believe they are right when they are wrong. At least the world knows what they are doing is not right. There will be as many religious people in hell as there will be outright sinners!

The church has been neutered by the world! We should ask ourselves:

- Could it be that in an effort to polish our programs and sermons we have lost our passion?

- Could it be that we have learned how to appeal to the consumer mind-set, and lost our commitment for the lost?
- Could it be that in our pursuit for prominence we have watered down the Gospel to the point that it has become ineffective?
- Could it be that we have become so civic minded that we no longer make Christ the center piece?
- Could it be that our focus has become so misplaced that we no longer consider eternity?

I believe in Methodology, but I also believe **the fire of God** must be in our preaching, teaching, singing, altars as well as the pews! 2 Corinthians 4:3-4 (NKJV) “**But if our gospel be hid, it is hid to them that are lost: 4 In whom the god of this world hath blinded the minds of them which believe not, lest the light of the glorious gospel of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine unto them.**” 1 Corinthians 1:21 (KJV) “***...It pleased God by the foolishness of preaching to save them that believe.***” We should make no apologies for our focus on preaching the

cross. The preaching of the cross is a matter of life and death. I am not trying to get you to be Assembly of God; I'm trying to convince you to receive Jesus and the life He has planned for you.

- Patrick Henry did not use a skit on Liberty and death; he lifted his voice full of passion and put his life where his mouth was!
- Winston Churchill did not use a talk show dialogue on courage under fire to rally the troops in World War II; he lifted his own steadfast courage before the people!

- Martin Luther King in his march on Washington lifted his voice and put flesh and blood in his dreams! He did not use a mime; he laid himself in harm's way!

I am certainly not against any of these things but I want you to know that no self-absorbed whining, cystic support group will ever raise the Church of the living God out of its self-inflicted, lethargic, comatose, half frozen condition! It will take the wind and fire of the Holy Ghost to resurrect the Church of the living God, and

cause them to go forth and once again conquer!

My prayer is *“Would you come, O God of the fire and wind, until we are consumed once again with a passion to have fellowship with God, and to reach a world on a toboggan sled to hell!”*

III. THE FIRE OF GOD!

The fire of God manifests itself in four ways:

- **Fire renovates** - The earth and works therein shall be burned up – out of this shall come a new heaven and a new earth. **2 Peter 3:10**

(NKJV) *“But the day of the Lord will come as a thief in the night, in which the heavens will pass away with a great noise, and the elements will melt with fervent heat; both the earth and the works that are in it will be burned up.”* Sodom & Gomorrah were destroyed by fire.

- **Fire exposes** - When burning off a forest or new ground, it is amazing how many rats and snakes will come running out of the fire! [Acts 28:3](#) (NKJV)
“But when Paul had gathered a bundle of sticks

***and laid them on the fire, a
viper came out because of
the heat, and fastened on
his hand.***” (He was not the

last preacher to get snake-bit while building a fire!)

There is no substitute for the fire of God. The fire of God will convict us of our sin; if we do not turn our back on it He will expose it!

- **Fire purifies** – The refiner’s fire burns until the dross has floated to the top and has been removed. The fire has not completed its purpose until the refiner can see his reflection in the silver! With His purifying fire He will

burn out every impurity!

[Zechariah 13:9](#) (NKJV) “*I*

will bring the one-third

through the fire, Will

refine them as silver is

refined, And test them as

gold is tested. They will call

on My name, and I will

answer them. I will say,

‘This is My people’; And

each one will say, ‘The

LORD is my God.’” [Malachi](#)

[3:2-3](#) (NKJV) “*But who*

can endure the day of His

coming? And who can

stand when He appears?

For He is like a refiner’s

fire And like launderer’s

soap. 3 He will sit as a

refiner and a purifier of silver; He will purify the sons of Levi, And purge them as gold and silver, That they may offer to the LORD An offering in righteousness.”

- **Fire empowers** – Think of the old steam driven trains. The fire and water combined to develop the steam. This furnished steam to blow the whistle, but more importantly, it enabled the loaded train to pull the hills. (Story of little train) So you see, the shout is good but the shout is only indicative of the power. The

whistle should mean the train is coming because the same power that blew the whistle will pull the train.

This power has produced victorious Christians, propelled missionaries to dark continents, purified hearts in believers; sought out sinners and turned them into saints, healed the sick and caused them to shout and shine; sent martyrs singing to their death. [Acts 1:8](#) (KJV)

“But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea,

and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.”

One day on the back side of the desert God wrapped Himself in a shrub and transformed a fugitive by the name of Moses into a mighty deliverer of his people.

On another occasion He took hold of a discouraged prophet by the name of Jeremiah. This prophet had become the object of a lot of misunderstanding and maltreatment. God became live fire in his bones and gave him a new lease on life as well as a fresh start. Jeremiah had been ready to join the

superannuated list and to speak no more in that name, but the consuming fire of God was like fire shut up in his bones!

In Isaiah six, with this same fire touching his lips, a timid prophet by the name of Isaiah was changed into a flaming messenger and he became one of the greatest prophets of all times. The consuming fire of God caused Isaiah to say “***Here am I Lord, send me!***”

Evangelist Vance Havner made the following statement: “*We have a lot of dead heads, figure heads, and hot heads, but what*

*we need are some hot hearts;
we need some people who run a
spiritual temperature for God.”*

Lord, give us cool heads and
warm hearts.

There are those who do not like
the Holy Ghost fire. If you have
no interest in the fire of God
you should go to the church
where Dr. Sounding Brass and
Evangelist Tinkling Symbol
give their lengthy discourse on
mind power, and better
methods of obtaining green
power. That's the church
where the thermometer never
rises higher than the freezing
point in the summer time. This

is the same church where the
sipping saints and puffing
pastors condone sin and cuddle
the carnal Christian!

You can attend that church if
you want to but I will tell you
that you will not find God in
the place! He is going to dwell
where men are seeking Him
and doing their best to follow
Him!

God as a fire in the Bible:

- In Genesis He is the fire of
creation...
- In Exodus He is the fire in
the burning bush...

- In Leviticus He is the fire that consumes our sin...
- In Numbers He is the fire among us...
- In Deuteronomy He is the voice of fire...
- In Joshua He is the fire that tears down walls...
- In Judges He is the fire that called Gideon and is here to call us...
- In Ruth He is the fire of commitment...
- In Samuel He is David's fire of deliverance...
- In Kings He is Elijah's fire that came down upon Mt Carmel...

- In Chronicles He is the Shekinah glory of fire...
- In Ezra He is the fire that restores the temple...
- In Nehemiah He is the fire of rebuilding...
- In Esther He is the fire of perseverance...
- In Job He is the fire of sustenance...
- In Psalms He is the fire that goes before us and follows after us...
- In Proverbs He is the fire of wisdom...
- In Ecclesiastes He is the fire that fills the void...

- In the Song of Solomon He is the fire of passion...
- In Isaiah He is the coal of fire that touches the lips of the prophet...
- In Jeremiah He is the fire in the kiln of the potter's house...
- In Lamentations He is the fire of compassion...
- In Ezekiel He is the fire that brings dry bones back to life...
- In Daniel He is the fire that will make you hotter than a fiery furnace...
- In Hosea He is the fire that rids the Church of Apostasy...

- In Joel He is the fire that brings national repentance and blessings...
- In Amos He is the fire of visions...
- In Obadiah He is the fire that makes a way where there seems to be no way...
- In Jonah He is the fire that causes an entire city to erupt in revival...
- In Micah He is the fire of repentance and deliverance...
- In Nahum He is the fire of destruction...
- In Habakkuk He is the fire of providence...

- In Zephaniah He is the fire that searches out the Judgments of God...
- In Haggai He is the fire that will rebuild the Temple...
- In Zechariah He is the fire of the long vision...
- In Malachi He is the fire of reform that prepares the way of the Lord...
- In the Gospels He is the fire incarnate... He is fire in the hands of the healer, in the hands of the deliverer, and He has promised to be the fire in the lives of those who will go in His name.
- In Acts He is the Holy Ghost and fire...

- In Romans He is the fire that consumes the living sacrifices...
- In Corinthians He is the fire that will judge our works...
- In Galatians He is the fire of the fruit of the Spirit...
- In Ephesians He is the fire of unity in the Church...
- In Philippians He is the fire of affection and gratitude...
- In Colossians He is the fire that makes Christ the head of the Church...
- In Thessalonians He is the fire that catches the Church away...

- In Timothy He is the fire of personal conduct and ministerial work...
- In Titus He is the fire of good works...
- In Philemon He is the fire of intercession...
- In Hebrews He is the fire that produces the flame in every one of us who are ministers...
- In James He is the fire of practical religion...
- In Peter He is the fire that purifies...
- In John He is the fire of fellowship, truth and love...

- In Jude He is the fire that is able to keep us from falling...
- In Revelation He is the fire that was, that is, and that always will be...

The fire of God is what has built this church to what it is. The fire of God is what it will take to cause us to be what God wants us to become.

God is not going to return the church to its' former glory – that's dead end faith, that's cul-de-sac faith. He's going to ignite a fire in us that the devil can't put out!!!

How is He going to do it? The same way He did it in Acts two; He is going to send the fire of God, and the wind of God!

No more sifting through the ashes of the past, God's about to do a new thing. [Isaiah 43:18-21](#) (CEV) ***“Forget what happened long ago! Don’t think about the past. 19 I am creating something new. There it is! Do you see it? I have put roads in deserts, streams in thirsty lands. 20 Every wild animal honors me, even jackals and owls. I provide water in deserts—streams in***

thirsty lands for my chosen people. 21 I made them my own nation, so they would praise me.”